

LIFESTYLE

INDEPENDENCE DAY SALE

7 - 16 AUG

FLAT 50% OFF*

T&C APPLY.

VISA

10% OFF

TAP TO PAY with your Visa Debit Cards & Visa Credit Cards* upto INR 600 on minimum spends INR 3000*



SHOP FROM 300+ INTERNATIONAL BRANDS

AT LIFESTYLE STORES AND LIFESTYLESTORES.COM

EXPRESS AVENUE MALL – ROYAPETTAH; PHOENIX MARKETCITY MALL – VELACHERY; NEXUS VIJAYA MALL – VADAPALANI; VR CHENNAI MALL – THIRUMANGALAM; MARINA MALL – EGATTUR; MOUNT POONAMALLEE RD, PORUR; AMPA SKYONE MALL – NELSON MANICKAM RD.

At the Hyundai India Couture Week 2026, Anamika Khanna's Hyderabad opener highlighted how couture must engage more closely with consumers beyond Delhi and Mumbai



(Clockwise from far left) JJ Valaya's show at Hyundai India Couture Week 2026; Aisha Rao's show; Rimzim Dadu's showcase; and JJ Valaya's men's collection. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Retail renaissance

Arnika Thakur

Anamika Khanna's India Couture Week (ICW) opening show in Hyderabad and Rahul Mishra's finale in Delhi offered a glimpse of high fashion's dual goals – spotlighting Indian creativity on a global stage and seizing the commercial opportunity at home, in centres outside Delhi and Mumbai. At ICW's inaugural showcase, Anamika's models walked the runway in pieces adorned with embroidery from Barmer and Kalighat paintings, at the Taj Falaknuma Palace in Hyderabad, a city with a growing number of ultra-rich individuals where she also opened a new store in 2025. In a first for ICW, the inaugural show occurred in a city outside of Delhi, highlighting the growing significance of centres such as Hyderabad, which boast of high-spending and discerning clients. Meanwhile, Rahul Mishra's finale was an expansion of his Paris Couture week showcase, with added

signature embellished gowns, saris and skirts, which will easily find takers at lavish Indian weddings at home and abroad. Mishra forayed into Hyderabad with a new store in Banjara Hills in 2024. From pearls, to the *khada* dupatta and majestic jewels of the Nizams of Hyderabad, high fashion isn't new to Hyderabad. The city also has its own crop of designers, such as Jayanti Reddy, Anushree Reddy, Aisha Rao, and Suhani Pittie, but some of India's top designers have only recently started to expand their physical presence in the city, helped by investments from Mukesh Ambani's Reliance Brands (RBL) and the Aditya Birla Group, besides the allure of a growing class of wealthy individuals. According to Knight Frank's 2026 wealth report, 80% of India's ultra-high-net-worth individuals (UHNWIs), those with a net worth \$30 million or more, are concentrated in five cities – Mumbai, Delhi, Bengaluru, Hyderabad and Chennai, with the capital of Telangana accounting for 6.3% of the uber rich. While Mumbai and Delhi



continue to be key markets, Indian fashion and luxury is seeing notable growth from consumers outside of these centres. "Now, aspirations are exactly the same everywhere," says Neelesh Hundekari, partner and head of fashion and luxury for Asia-Pacific at Kearney, adding the comparatively lower cost of venues and related services means wealthy consumers can dedicate a larger share of the wedding budget to jewellery and designer clothing. The cost of real estate is lower in cities such as Hyderabad, Chennai, Kolkata, Bengaluru and beyond, compared to Delhi and Mumbai, which could translate into higher margins for brands. Besides, "big cities are saturated.

(Consumers in smaller cities) have aligned themselves with whatever's happening in the world," says designer JJ Valaya. Designers believe fashion consumers are more aware everywhere in India, thanks to social media and growing affluence. "When we first started experimenting with metal and came up with the steel saree, brides were unsure. They wanted to wear it but sought advice from their relatives if it would be apt for the occasion. Now, women know exactly what they want, they're not seeking approval," says Rimzim Dadu. She notes the label's clients from cities such as Hyderabad, Kolkata and Nagpur attended her show in Delhi.

Beyond Delhi and Mumbai Last year, her new store opened its doors to consumers in Hyderabad's upscale Banjara Hills. The city was also the location for Tarun Tahiliani's grand 30th anniversary show earlier this year. Sabyasachi unveiled new boutiques in Bengaluru and Hyderabad in 2025; Indian and global luxury and fashion brands across value segments are solidifying their presence in cities such as Chennai, Kolkata, Ahmedabad, Pune, Raipur, Ludhiana, and others, which also act as a catchment area for the region. Earlier this year, Off-White opened a store in Bengaluru, multi-brand watch retailer TimeVallée opened a boutique in Chennai, Ralph Lauren forayed into Kolkata in 2025, while Aditya Birla's multi-brand fashion chain The Collective, which retails brands such as Karl Lagerfeld and Michael Kors, has expanded into Patiala, Jalandhar and Raipur within the last two years. Ogaan unveiled a new Chennai location in 2025, while Sanjay Garg

debuted a Raw Mango boutique in Kolkata last year. Valaya, who has a JJV Kapurthala store in Ludhiana, says the idea behind his bridge to luxury line was to make it more accessible. "It resonated with so many people that I'm able to take this line into smaller cities. I wouldn't have thought of Ludhiana for couture... I can think of it now, I can seriously think of Chandigarh, Jaipur, or Ahmedabad. There is a whole ecosystem opening up, tier 2 and tier 3 cities are becoming very open to embracing luxury," he says.

Overseas clients "We've established that cities like Raipur or Nagpur shop a lot but when someone travels from somewhere like Guwahati for a wedding, that's still a big thing for me. It's not just the distance but Guwahati is barely ever in mainstream fashion conversation," says Rimzim, adding clients from Bangladesh and Nepal are becoming common too. At her stores, the designer notes that while the core product design remains consistent, merchandising strategies are tailored to specific city markets. Clients in Hyderabad tend to shop more spontaneously, often just one to two weeks before an event, according to Rimzim, which means her store in the city is merchandised with pieces that have shorter production lead times or are readily available off-the-rack. Arpita Mehta, who presented her debut couture collection at ICW, says, "Hyderabad has a refined sense of dressing that feels elegant and sophisticated, often favouring timeless craftsmanship. Chandigarh brings a playful energy, with an openness to experimenting... Chennai has a quieter, more understated approach." Designers highlight regional preferences are becoming more fluid. Designer Aisha Rao believes personal style now plays a far greater role than location. It is, however "exciting to see couture resonate across emerging markets throughout the country, where customers are increasingly seeking pieces that balance individuality, craftsmanship and modern elegance," says Aisha. Top designers report higher demand from smaller cities, yet they remain cautious about physical expansion, a stance that may shift as corporate investors push for growth through expansion in profitable new markets.



(Clockwise from left) A Japanese shiitake mushroom biryani; Chef Takamasa Osawa. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Biryani diplomacy

Japanese Chef Takamasa Osawa runs a Michelin Guide-recognised, biryani-only restaurant in Tokyo. At Mumbai's Indian Accent, he served a limited menu that sold out before he landed

Nivedita Jayaram Pawar

Takamasa Osawa did not travel to India in search of biryani. In fact, when he first arrived in Tamil Nadu in 2009, he barely knew what it was. Hungry, he ordered what seemed like just another rice dish. "The first time I tried it, it was so delicious that I wanted to try it again. Then I wanted to try another variety. It shocked me," he says. Over the next 16 years, the Tokyo-based chef would return to

India repeatedly, travelling across the country, tasting regional styles, studying ingredients and refining his understanding of one of India's most fiercely debated dishes. Today, his restaurant, Biryani Osawa in Tokyo, has earned recognition from the Michelin Guide and is one of the city's hardest tables to book. For a Japanese chef to build his reputation around biryani may seem unusual. For Takamasa, however, the attraction was never novelty. It is the complexity of the dish. "Though the protein gives the biryani its umami, the rice should

be delicious even on its own. But the balance of the spices decides everything. Finding that balance is what makes biryani," he says. Among the many styles he has tasted, the Hyderabadi layered biryani remains his favourite. "In Hyderabad, if it isn't layered, it's pulao, not biryani. The layering and the balance of spices are extremely important," he says with a smile.

Grain expectations Over the years, he has compared varieties of basmati rice, experimented with cooking temperatures and evaluated spices from different countries before settling entirely on ingredients sourced from India. "If I want to make the perfect biryani, I have to choose the best ingredients. I tried all the basmati rice available in Japan, but the one from Punjab was the best. Sadly spices grown in India taste different by the time they reach Japan as they are



heat-treated before shipping. That changes their aroma completely," he says. Takamasa believes, "Biryani always tastes best when it's made in large quantities. My secret is to always make biryani fresh and serve it immediately. While making the gravy and tenderising the meat, I cook over a high flame because higher temperatures create more aroma." At his restaurant in Tokyo, diners are encouraged to begin eating together so that everyone experiences the biryani at the same moment. He serves it with enamel spoons because he believes they preserve the flavour better than metal and pairs it with cola chilled to -1 degree Celsius, convinced that the temperature complements the richness of the dish. While his lamb and chicken biryanis remain faithful to traditional recipes, Takamasa is open to borrowing ideas from Japanese cooking if he believes they improve the dish. One example is his shiitake mushroom biryani, where the mushrooms are sautéed in butter and soy sauce before being layered into the rice. "I grew up in the mountains, so mushrooms are my favourite food. But I was surprised by how well soy sauce paired with the spices. It almost smells like caramelised onions." "The process and the ingredients should never be a limit. If a cooking technique from Thailand or French cuisine makes biryani taste better, it should be welcomed. What matters is the final taste," he believes. I tasted his lamb biryani during his collaboration at Indian Accent, Mumbai. The spices were subtle but deeply flavourful. There was a gentle tang from the yoghurt, sweetness from the birista and rice that was perfectly cooked. The chicken biryani was slightly drier, while the shiitake mushroom version brought a distinctly Japanese note.

Biryani Osawa, is at Kanda, Tokyo, and a meal for one is priced at 3,200 ¥

Dosa Down Under

Bengaluru's 100-year-old MTR restaurant is all set to brings its idlis and dosas to Sydney, Australia



Rava idli at MTR in Bengaluru. K BHAGYA PRAKASH

Anagha Maareesha
anagha.maareesha@thehindu.co.in

Mavalli Tiffin Rooms opened in Bengaluru 100 years ago. The tiffin room in Lalbagh has its loyal following and is loved for its dosas, and the rava idli, a dish that they invented during the Second World War due to rice shortages. Now, MTR is all set to open a restaurant in Sydney, Australia, this September. Hemamalini Maiya, the custodian of the family brand and managing partner, MTR Restaurants, said, "We had an interest in Australia for some time now. But finding chefs, training them and getting the visas take time." However, she says the plan is all on track now, and they are aiming to launch at the end of September. "Sydney is supposed to be one of the

best markets for Indian food," she says. **Homegrown flavours** "The menu we have in Bengaluru is the same menu we will have there," Hemalini says. So diners can enjoy many types of dosas, khara bhath, vadas and bisibele bhath. The chefs in the Sydney outlet will be taken from India. The group had to find people who are eligible as the country is very strict about its visa laws. They found chefs who could speak English, who were then trained in the restaurant's traditions and recipes. "All the masalas used in the kitchens will go to Australia from Bengaluru. There, we only source the rice and the dals from local Indian stores," she adds. MTR has 12 restaurants internationally in cities such as Seattle, Bangkok, Bristol, Toronto and Dubai.

weekend
wkcd

COMING FULL CIRCLE

Actor Siddharth on playing an IAF pilot in *Operation Safed Sagar*, and the show's uncanny *Rang De Basanti* connect **P3**

metroPLUS THE  HINDU

buses without a destination, exploring unfamiliar neighbourhoods before heading back on another route. “We bought old papers by the kilogram at Kothaval Chavadi and searched Moore Market for forgotten books and discarded objects,” says Krishnaswamy.

He would spend countless hours at Albert Theatre and Devi Theatre watching films. A plate of onion rava dosa at Kaveri Hotel often completed the day.

Giri Trading and Perumal Chetty & Sons were their regular stops for art material, and they would buy canvases near the old Rolex Hotel.

“Those years remain within me like breath itself. They shaped the way I see, think, and create. Madras did not simply educate me; it became an inseparable part of my artistic practice,” says Krishnaswamy.

His ongoing work at Ashvita's explores ecological memory and humanity's enduring relationship with the land. Drawing inspiration from the Ayyanar tradition of southern India as an ancient expression of guardianship, the works revisit village shrines where clay guardian figures symbolised the bond between earth, memory, and community, reimagining these ideas for the present.

Benitha Perciyal K at British Council

Benitha Perciyal K arrived in Madras from Tiruvannamalai as a student in 1995, a move she describes as both a culture shock and a turning point in her artistic journey. During her years at college, from 1995 until she completed her Master's degree in 2002, the city became a space of constant discovery.

“Moving from a small town to a metropolitan city was a culture shock at first. But slowly, as I explored the city and the college, it changed my perspective,” she says. It was through institutions such as the British Council, Alliance Française and Max Mueller Bhavan that she discovered world cinema, contemporary theatre, literature and conversations with artists and writers. “Those years were not just about studying Art. They exposed me to literature, theatre, cinema, and writers. It became a multidimensional learning experience, and in many ways, Madras transformed how I saw myself and my practice. That experience has stayed with me since,” she says.

For Contemporary Now, Benitha will present a section from her long-running library series, an evolving body of work she has been developing for over a decade. Featuring hand-carved wooden books arranged as bookshelves, the installation draws on texts spanning ecology, medicine, history and archival knowledge, including titles dating back centuries.

**CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 2**

Priyamedha Dutta
priyamedha.dutta@thehindu.co.in

Long before Chennai became synonymous with contemporary art, the city was forging a distinct visual language of its own. The Madras Movement of the 1960s, led by KCS Paniker at the Government College of Arts and Crafts, drew on indigenous scripts, folk forms, and abstraction rather than looking westward. Together with the Cholamandal Artists' Village, it laid the foundations for a movement that would shape generations of artists and leave an enduring imprint on Indian modern and contemporary art.

That legacy comes into focus once again with Contemporary Now – Edition III, a 20-day citywide exhibition that brings together 66 artists, seven leading galleries, and a programme of exhibitions, conversations, artist walkthroughs, and open houses across Chennai. Against this backdrop, we speak to artists with roots in Chennai to understand how the city has shaped their artistic language, practice and ways of seeing the world.

C Krishnaswamy at Central station

For artist C Krishnaswamy, studying at the Government College of Arts and Crafts from 1991 to 1996 (now Government College of Fine Arts), Madras, education began on the campus but extended beyond that. "That was a time when Madras itself became my art school."

He recalls wandering through Central and Egmore stations, sketching around the Government Museum and St Andrews Church, spending afternoons at the American Consulate Library, the British Library, and Higginbothams in search of books on the world's great artists.

Armed with a student bus pass, he and his friends would board

Our city as *muse*

From old libraries and TASMAC outlets to Kasimedu's fishing neighbourhoods, five artists recall the Madras that shaped the way they see and make art



JOCKEY

FACTORY SECONDS UPTO

50

OFF*

10 am to 8 pm • Open All Days • Master / Visa Card Accepted

INNERWEAR • LEISUREWEAR • ACTIVEWEAR • KIDSWEAR • SOCKS

Venues In Chennai

Ashok Nagar	: Lakshmi Hall, 50/40, 100 Feet Road, Near Ashok Pillar, Opp. CSI Church
Cathedral Road	: Dass Community Hall No.55, Gopalapuram, Opp. Hotel Chola Sheraton
Egmore	: Guild of Service, 18, Casa Major Road
Anna Nagar	: D. K. Mahal, W-114, 3rd Avenue, Near Roundtanna
Ambattur	: Arul Jothi Kalyana Mandapam, 162 A, Ambattur Redhills High Road, Near Rakki Cinemas
OMR Sholinganallur	: K.V.L Kalyana Mahal, 161, Opp. Accenture, Opp. Bharat Petroleum

* T & C apply
 Org. by: Surya Agency Pvt. Ltd.





Sangeetha
VEG RESTAURANT
— SINCE 1985 —

ONAM SADHYA

TRADITIONAL FEAST MADE WITH LOVE

26 AUGUST, 2026 | 11:00AM - 3:00PM

Chennai's 1st vegetarian restaurant to serve Onam Sadhya since 1999.
Thanking our customers for your continued love and support!




PRE BOOKINGS ONLY
FOR DINE IN, TAKEAWAY & DELIVERY

DINE IN ₹900 + 5% GST SERVES 1	TAKE AWAY ₹1050 + 5% GST SERVES 1	HOME DELIVERY ₹1250 + 5% GST SERVES 1
---	--	--

31 CURATED DISHES



AVAILABLE ONLY AT

ADYAR
NO.7, GANDHI NAGAR,
FIRST MAIN ROAD, ADYAR
CHENNAI 600020
📞 9003003087

VIRUGAMBAKKAM
93, ARCOT ROAD, NEXT TO
CHANDRA MALL INOX THEATRE,
VIRUGAMBAKKAM, CHENNAI 600092
📞 7823958667

ANNA NAGAR
NEW 86, OLD 16, 3RD AVENUE,
BLOCK 3, ANNA NAGAR EAST,
CHENNAI 600101
📞 8680001379

To Pre-book, call: 9003003090
Bookings close on: 23 August, 2026

Available on  **SWIGGY zomato**
www.sangeethavegonline.com



*Terms & Conditions Apply | *Prices mentioned are exclusive of tax | *Items are subject to availability

pick of the week



Flea market hop

Looking for a slower way to spend your Saturday? Head to Madras Flea, where over 35 homegrown brands, including JuiceBerry, Anglo Aunty's Kitchen, BLND.EAT, Darshitam and Saavii, come together with fashion, home décor, handcrafted goods and artisanal finds. Browse independent labels, enjoy food from local vendors and explore workshops at *The Folly, Amethyst*, on August 8, from 11am to 8pm. Entry is free.



Rain, paint, repeat

Rainy days and art make the perfect pair. The Monsoon of Art, curated by Sunshine House, arrives at Backyard bringing together artists, like Art by Methaa, Hues by Sarah, The Dusky Doodler, Red Eye Chapters, Mojo Canvas, Vandy's, The Bookmark and Co. and more. Also expect art stalls, artist conversations, monsoon-inspired music, and warm comfort food. On August 9, at Backyard, Adyar from 2pm to 8pm. Follow @backyardclan on Instagram for more information.



Reel conversations

Catch two compelling Tamil independent short films at MFSC #Spotlight on August 8, from 4.30pm to 8.30pm at ArtKin Centre, Alwarpet. The screenings feature *Roja Towers*, directed by singer-songwriter Susantika, and *Vicky & Candy Forever* by filmmaker Kevin Jeremy. Stay on for a post-screening conversation with both directors as they discuss their creative journeys, influences and the making of their films. Tickets are available online on kynhood.com



Laksa after dark

Michelin-star Chef Manjunath Mural is swapping fine dining for bar bites at The Quarter with a one-night Southeast Asian feast. Dig into dishes like tom yum pani puri, rojak chaat, laksa prawns with lemon leaf upma, chicken rendang and murtabak chicken, before ending with coconut trim cake. At *The Quarter, Chennai*, on August 9, from 7pm onwards. Entry: ₹2,500 (redeemable) per person. For reservations: 9841310006.

Woven by Santhal women from Mayurbhanj, Panchaa reimagines the Santhali weave in a line of dhotis

S Poorvaja

poorvaja.sundar@thehindu.co.in

Stripes of black, orange and red. Tiny black fish swimming in threes. Checkered blues. Imagine all of this on dhotis, the ubiquitous South Indian garment more commonly associated with crisp white fabric, edged in solid colours or gold.

While it traditionally features in saris woven by the Santhal tribal community, the Santhali weave now finds a place on the dhoti through Panchaa, an initiative by Ramraj Cotton. This limited-edition launch, features 11 different designs on eight-yard dhotis handwoven in cotton with an off-white base and azo-free dyes.

This coming-together of weaves is unusual: a garment traditionally from the South, a company that has its roots in Tamil Nadu, and a weave that originates from the forests and far-flung areas of Odisha. For Bindu Vinodhan, founder, Mauna Dhvani foundation who has spent close to a decade working on the revival of the Santhali weave, collaborating with weavers in Mayurbhanj, a project with Chennai-based photographer, author and documentary filmmaker Amar Ramesh set the ball rolling.

At the culmination of this project, Amar approached Ramraj with two dhotis woven in the Santhali weave. “They



Models don dhotis from the Panchaa line. AMAR RAMESH

Stripes, checks and dhotis

were amazed at how beautifully it came together and decided to work with the weavers directly, to reimagine the weave and bring out a contemporary dhoti,” Amar says.

“Among the Santhali community, weaving had begun to decline as people migrated in search of other livelihoods. Within two or three generations, the tradition had nearly disappeared. Over the last decade, we worked on reviving the weave, facilitated setting up looms and more. Everything is done here by them from scratch,” says Bindu.

There are now over 800 weavers, all of whom are



women. Bindu says they handle everything from pre-processing, dyeing, and have even begun to grow cotton, something that had stopped when colonisation happened.

Unique weave

Bindu recalls how when she initially approached the Santhal community, there was little knowledge about the facets of their traditional weave.

“Traditionally, they were buried with their clothes when they died. So we did not have any references to go by, given that the weaves had been largely lost for a few years. Someone then managed to find an old sari

which was locked away in a trunk somewhere, and we used that garment for our initial lessons about the weave,” she says.

On garments such as the sari, the weave appears like embroidery, almost as if an ornate layer has been stitched on the fabric when the designs are actually, directly woven into the fabric. “An extra-weft technique is used for this weave, which is characterised by a distinctive rib pattern,” says Bindu. “The loom itself requires four pedals

instead of the usual two, and the weaving process takes time, and is highly labour-intensive.”

“This weave is a treasure, and we think it deserves a wider audience without losing its authenticity. Through Panchaa, we have reimaged this traditional weave as a dhoti, and we hope that this initiative encourages greater appreciation for the weave and strengthens the livelihoods of the women weavers,” says KR Nagarajan, founder and chairman, Ramraj Cotton.

While he says that dhoti purists, who prefer their crisp whites might not immediately gravitate towards this reimaged line, he is sure that the designs will be a hit among youngsters. “They are constantly looking for something new, and we believe these designs will find an audience among them,” he adds.

With Onam around the corner and the larger festive and wedding season coming up in the next few months, the time is ripe to put a spin on those whites.

Panchaa is available at www.ramrajcotton.com and in select stores. Priced at ₹3,999.



CONTINUED FROM
» PAGE 1

This deeply personal journey explores themes of memory, displacement, faith, and belonging.

Suresh Kumar P at Kasimedu Suresh Kumar P, a contemporary artist, sculptor and one of the founding members of the KINETICS collective, credits Chennai with shaping the way he sees the world. “Chennai has been the foundation of my artistic journey,” he says.

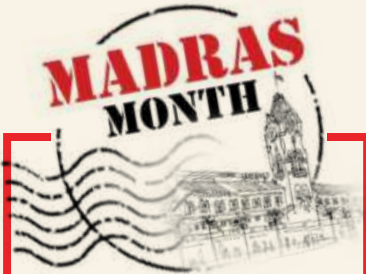
Having studied at the Government College of Fine Arts, he remembers a city that was quieter and slower, where observation became second nature. “The college campus, with its lush greenery, gave me a peaceful environment where observing became a way of learning,” he recalls.

Sketching landscapes, colonial buildings and landmarks such as Anderson Church, along with painting the fishing neighbourhood

Madras as muse

of Kasimedu, became formative experiences. While the city has transformed over the last 25 years, Suresh says those memories continue to inform his practice. “Although my work has evolved into abstraction, the attention to colour, atmosphere and the poetry of everyday life that I discovered in Chennai continues to shape my work,” says Suresh.

Showcasing as part of Gallery Veda for Contemporary Now, his Untitled abstract paintings emerge from fleeting moments of beauty, discovered in everyday environments, from Nature to urban landscapes and overlooked spaces. Through an intuitive, meditative process, he transforms



On August 22, 1639, the transaction that laid the foundation for the city of Madras was signed, a date now celebrated every year as Madras Day. This month our reporters will be celebrating the city with stories. Watch this space.



(Clockwise from far left) Untitled artwork by Suresh Kumar; Punishment (2025) by Jagath Ravi; and Sentiuous (2026) by C Krishnaswamy. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



man cooking with liquor bottles on the side and fish bags from a fish export market in North Chennai's Kolathur. “People often label these men as drunkards, but I wanted to show their innocence,” he says. “I wasn't trying to make a statement. I was simply journalling the little beauty in what already existed.” By documenting these unremarkable moments, Maanas invites viewers to look beyond stereotypes and recognise the tenderness embedded in the city's everyday culture.

Jagath Ravi is home

Jagath Ravi, who has spent his entire life in Chennai, says that the city has shaped both his life and his artistic practice. “From childhood until now, I have never lived anywhere else, which makes me deeply rooted in this city,” he says. Having watched Madras evolve over the years, he believes he has changed alongside it. “The city has shaped how I see, respond, and engage with the world, and this influence is quietly reflected in my work.” Rather than looking out to grand landmarks, Jagath draws from the emotional texture of everyday happenings around him.

For the show, Jagath presents his work titled Punishment (2025), a painting inspired by a playful exchange between a teacher and a student that helps foster better understanding between them. The work reimagines punishment not as an act of authority but as a simple playful gesture.

For some, Chennai was an art school beyond the classroom; for others, it was the streets, libraries, theatres, fishing harbour and everyday rituals that became a source of inspiration. Together, these artists reveal that the city's greatest legacy lies not only in the Madras Movement it once nurtured, but also in its continued ability to shape generations of practitioners.

Contemporary Now Edition-III begins today. For details follow @contemporarynow on Instagram.



Actor Siddharth, along with Jimmy Shergill and creator-showrunner Kushal Srivastava, discuss their show *Operation Safed Sagar* based on the real-life hero, Squadron Leader Ajay Ahuja

Shreyas Pande
shreyas.pande@thehindu.co.in

Twenty years ago, Siddharth stood on the other side. Playing a brooding, charismatic, and cynical youngster, Karan, in *Rang De Basanti* (2006), the actor's heated discussions with his best friend, Ajay (R Madhavan), an idealistic Air Force pilot, formed the film's thematic core. So, when Ajay passed his leather jacket to Karan in a memorable scene, it became a striking symbol of the baton of responsibility being passed. Ajay stirred an awakening in Karan.

The spirit of that film returns to Siddharth as he takes on the role of a fighter pilot in the Netflix series, *Operation Safed Sagar*. Not just that, his character is named Ajay too, based on the real-life hero, Squadron Leader Ajay Ahuja. "The coincidences are ridiculous," says Siddharth as he recollects a conversation he had with Air Chief Marshal BS Dhanoa, played by Jimmy Shergill in the series. Dhanoa jokingly referred to a scene from *Rang De Basanti* in which Karan criticises the aircraft MiG-21 after the death of his friend. "He said, 'Iss baar tum MiG ko gaali nahi doge na (You won't speak badly about MiG this time, right?)','" the actor says with a smile.

"I don't think even Maddy's character would speak badly about the MiG if he were alive in that film, as the life of a soldier is different. So, in *Operation Safed Sagar*, I got to experience what my best friend's character goes through in *Rang De Basanti*," he says, adding that he sat in a fighter jet during the show's shoot. "I don't know what I did to deserve it. If 20 years later, the same coincidences happen in another form, then I have no complaints."

Flight of duty



The preparation process for the role also involved detailed air procedures to add believability to the part. Siddharth feels that the heavy-lifting in making them look authentic was done by the creators. "As actors, our job is to just pretend something we are not. For that, we try to understand the world. But a lot of the preparation is already done on paper by the writers, which is then achieved further by other members of the crew," he says.

It is the first time the actor donned the Air Force uniform, bringing his easy-going charm to



portray the sincerity of the late Ajay Ahuja. Siddharth was aware of the weight of that responsibility. "It was special because I was portraying the life of Ahuja sir. I also got to spend time with the pilots on the base. Every day brought real jolts. I didn't take any day less seriously than the other. So, wearing the uniform felt heavy to me," he says.

For Jimmy, who has played a cop, an Army man, and an Air Force officer multiple times, the uniform is a matter of pride. "It changes your body language the moment you wear it. You feel the strength on your chest, and with a turban on the head, it further adds to the power," he says.

Jimmy also brings restraint to his performance as he is shown guiding other officers. He is not dramatic while projecting authority, but makes it even more apparent with pauses and subtle eye glances. The actor says he followed the brief given by director Oni Sen. "It was important to bring out the human side of these soldiers. If you meet them, they



Skills from the show. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

don't look like Superman; their sacrifices make them heroes, not the appearance or the shouting. I think that was also the brief given to the makers from the Air Force to keep the tone closer to reality," says Jimmy.

A part of that nuanced layering makes its way into the show, as it is created and showrun by Kushal Srivastava, who has served in the Air Force. "The actual life of the Air Force has not quite come together on-screen. We have mostly seen it as an extension of the Army. But Air

Force officers need to be calm and composed as they are dealing with high pressure while flying at high altitudes," says Kushal.

Siddharth concurs that *Operation Safed Sagar* is more of an emotional experience than an adrenaline charged one. "I am a history buff; I have read a lot, particularly about warfare, be it the First World War or Second World War. But this show is not about warfare. It is not an action series. So, we have performed it from the heart and not from the mind," Siddharth says.

The show also marks the actor's return to Hindi after his regular presence in Tamil and Telugu productions. When asked if he is looking for something specific while considering a Hindi project, the actor says, "I want people to look for me; then I will consider the project," he smiles. "I don't go around looking for work; people have to come to me with work, as I anyway do two-three projects every year."

Siddharth feels he is blessed to be a polyglot and that he was considered for the role of a Punjabi from Rajasthan in *Operation Safed Sagar*. "The same kindness was shown by the makers of *Rang De Basanti* 20 years ago when they approached me to play Bhagat

Singh and Karan Singhania. I am not from this world at all. That's one of the main reasons I feel I should continue being an actor because, 20 years apart, I have got two projects that make me feel this is the correct job for me," he concludes.

Operation Safed Sagar is now streaming on Netflix

HYPE INDIA CEO Damien Wochang Lee, on auditions for an India-based global girl group, and whether BTS could perform in India

S Poorvaja
poorvaja.sundar@thehindu.co.in

How does one become a music star? For legions of young K-pop fans in India, the origin stories of their favourite idols, from rising through South Korea's underground rap scene to being scouted by casting agents on the streets of their hometowns, have always held a near-mythical appeal.

Over the last three months, many fans have gotten to try their hand at giving the pop star dream a shot. HYPE, the global entertainment company behind K-Pop groups like BTS, TOMORROW X TOGETHER, and LE SSERAFIM, recently concluded a multi-city audition process through HYPE INDIA to scout for aspiring musical talent in India, across cities, to form an India-based global girl group.

The response for the in-person auditions – which were held through April, May and June in Chennai, Mumbai, Guwahati, Chandigarh, Hyderabad, Delhi and other cities – was higher than their expectations, says Damien Wochang Lee, CEO, HYPE INDIA. "We are very grateful for the belief they have in our programme, the training and music development we believe in," he says.

Local at heart
Reflecting on the auditions, which he says went 'spectacularly well', Damien further points out that there was also an option to apply and submit audition tapes online, which many young aspiring artists used. HYPE's internal talent development and casting teams, which include music professionals, leadership teams, and experienced casting partners like Panchami Ghavri from India (who has worked on casting for films such as *Geheraiyaan* and *Kapoor & Sons*), have been involved in the audition



The popstar hunt

process. The result, Damien says, is a group that is Indian at its core, but a music act that resonates globally. "It was important for us to have a diverse approach to ensure that candidates are evaluated holistically across key areas such as talent, performance, and long-term development. While I understand that an audition might be a short window for a candidate to prove themselves, the most important area we look for is potential, and then we take it from there," Damien says.

The audition process will be followed by the announcement of the chosen candidates and will then lead to a rigorous training period, much like what K-pop idols go through before they make their music debut.

The decision to hold auditions in India and debut a global girl group comes on the heels of the success of

Los Angeles-based HYPE girl group KATSEYE, as well as the growing popularity of the company's K-pop acts LE SSERAFIM and ILLIT. Earlier this year, all three groups collaborated on the single 'Iconic By Mistake', underscoring HYPE's push to build a connected global pop ecosystem.

The India chapter
Hybe INDIA set up its headquarters in Mumbai in September last year. Damien notes that while music consumption in India pre-COVID was highly bent towards film music, there has been a sharp increase in the consumption of independent music, thanks to the evolving tastes of younger listeners, which continued post-pandemic.

And with BTS currently on their mega Arirang world tour, we have to ask: is India going to be a possible tour stop?

"While I cannot comment on anything at the moment, I would like to say that I am trying," Damien says. "India is one of the most exciting live music markets in the world today, and we have seen tremendous growth in fan engagement and demand for global artists. We absolutely recognise the enthusiasm of Indian fans for BTS and other HYPE artistes, and we are actively exploring opportunities to bring more fan experiences and global artistes to India over time," he adds.

(Above) Members of Illit, LE SSERAFIM, and Katseye; (left) Damien Wochang Lee. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

MAGGI® Ready Family Jolly!

your favourite masala taste

2-Minute noodles

MADE WITH QUALITY SPICES & RICHNESS OF TON

Good food. Good life.

Creative Visualization. Refer pack for more details. Enjoy your MAGGI® noodles (steamed, dried and fried) and consume a variety of other foods like vegetables, fruits and milk.



runs through it

With its pristine rivers and thriving trout population, Mechuka has the potential to be a hugely popular angling destination

Preeti Zachariah
preeti.zachariah@thehindu.co.in

Neega Ngurang began fishing as a child, “local style” with a “bamboo pole rod, using a single monoline and one hook,” recalls the sports angler, river guide, and content creator from Sagalee, near Itanagar in Arunachal Pradesh. In 2013, he discovered angling and was hooked – pun intended. “I did not know what sport fishing was, but when I saw a spinning rod on television, I realised that I also wanted to buy it and learn how to use it,” says Neega, who spent the next two years practising angling in the rivers in and around where he lived. “As I gained experience, I also picked up the catch-and-release technique used in sport fishing, and began attending competitions.”

Today, he runs training programmes on angling and also a popular fishing YouTube channel, Neega Fishing Adventures, through which he educates people about the sport. “You have to experience it to understand it. It is really fun,” he says.

Neega was recently in Mechuka, Arunachal Pradesh, to attend the second edition of the Mechuka Trout Quest, an annual angling championship, held



How much does it cost?

Derek says that an average fishing starter kit starts under ₹3,000 for an unbranded version and ₹5,000 for a branded one, though specialised kits can go into lakhs. Other expenses may include lures, costing anywhere between ₹250-800, and fishing licenses, which “range from ₹500 for pond fishing to ₹1,500 per angler in rivers for Indian nationals and ₹3,000 for foreigners”. When it comes to competitions in India, an Indian angler from outside the State where the contest occurs is likely to spend anywhere between ₹20-50,000 — excluding the registration fee — just for travel, stay, food, and local transport. “Outside India, we can end up spending between ₹2-5 lakhs,” says Derek.

between July 25 and 26, which saw 56 elite competitors from within and outside the country, including Bobby Satpal, widely recognised as one of India’s top fly anglers, and Tup Meesupwatana, a popular professional angler and YouTuber from Thailand.

Organised by the State’s Department of Tourism, the Mechuka Trout Quest is envisioned as a flagship international angling event designed to position Arunachal Pradesh as a leader in high-value, low-impact eco-tourism,

(Clockwise from left) A participant at the Mechuka Trout Quest; State Tourism Minister Pasang Dorjee Sona; and Bhutanese angler Sonam Tshering. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Mechuka calling

How to get there: The nearest airport is Dibrugarh, a 370-km journey by road. There is also a chopper service twice a week, on Monday and Friday, from Itanagar. **What to see:** Yargyap Chu river banks, Dorjeeling Village, Buddha Park, Samten Choeling Monastery, Gonpa Samten Yangchag Heritage Museum, Guru Nanak Taposthan, Lamang Border. **Where to stay:** There are a number of affordable homestays in Mechuka, such as the Hornbill, Owa, Mae and Yargyap-Chu Cottage Homestay.

according to the pre-event press release. “The landscape is already endowed with Nature, and we have many places to visit,” says Pasang Dorjee Sona, the local MLA and the State’s Tourism Minister who also serves as the Minister of Education, Rural Works, Parliamentary Affairs and Libraries. “That is why this idea came up.”

An emerging sport

Though traditional line and net sustenance fishing is and has been prevalent in India for millennia, angling as a recreational sport is a relatively modern phenomenon here. First practised by homesick British officials, it is still an emerging sport in the country, says tournament director Derek Dsouza, the India representative of the International Game Fishing Association (IGFA). Interest in it is rising, however, and he believes that it has potential to grow in the country “because we have a large coastline and a lot of big rivers”.

In recent years, Arunachal Pradesh, particularly Mechuka, has been on the map of the angling community. Among the popular game trout are the brown and rainbow trout, both of which were introduced by the British to India in the 19th and 20th centuries. “Mechuka is one of the few places in Arunachal Pradesh where we have trout. The climatic conditions are conducive because it is a cold-water fish,” explains Fisheries Minister Gabriel Denwang, adding that the State plans to invest heavily in trout farming. “It would help us boost tourism in this area,” he says. The pine-studded, emerald

slopes of the Eastern Himalayas loom as Sonam Tshering reels in a brown trout, the early morning sun gleaming off its tawny, speckled body. He then scoops the fish into a soft net and gently unhooks it before crouching in the pellucid waters of the Yargyap Chu River, fish in hands, to pose for a photograph taken by a waiting marshal. A sudden splash as the fish is released and quickly skitters away, while Sonam straps the net to his back and wades back deeper with his rod, all ready for his next catch.

Trout tourism

But it is not the actual catch that draws Sonam to the sport. “I just like the experience,” says the Bhutanese angler, who participated in and won the fly fishing category at the Mechuka Trout Quest this year. He adds, “I enjoy being in Nature, wading through the water, learning about the river structures and trout behaviour.” Nasreen Sultana Naaz, the sole female angler among the participants, echoes Sonam’s view. “The best part about angling is that I get to travel and see all these beautiful destinations. We live chaotic, urban lives, but once you come to an angling spot, it is completely different,” she says.

Like Sonam and Nasreen, most anglers love coming to off-beat places like Mechuka to fish, says Derek, who believes that angling can indeed play a significant role in boosting sustainable ecotourism. “Anglers don’t need to have expensive accommodation, just a pristine river. And if they have that, it could lead to a significant economic boom in a place,” he says, pointing out that anglers are largely responsible tourists, who ensure that they keep their surroundings clean, respect Nature and are willing to pay well for an angling experience.

Minister Dorjee Sona, too, is aware that tourism models need to be developed carefully in Arunachal Pradesh, which, like most of its northeastern counterparts, is ecologically fragile and vulnerable to large-scale development. “We want to have niche tourism only. I’ve been vocal about saying that, and the best part is our people are also aware of this,” he says. Instead, the target is a very specific sort of tourist, “the adventure seekers,” with the focus now on creating better infrastructure for adventure sports like kayaking, mountain biking, mountaineering and, of course, angling.

Based on the success of the first two editions of the trout quest, it now likely to be a permanent fixture on the angling map. “The anglers absolutely loved it,” says Derek. “If we continue the same path we are going and get more people’s support, this could be one of the best trout destinations in the world.”

The writer was at Mechuka on invitation from Arunachal Pradesh’s Ministry of Tourism.



Curated fashion in focus

The latest edit of Arti Bagdy Fashion Collezione (ABFC) celebrates festive elegance with contemporary relevance, says Arti Bagdy. “We are bringing heritage jewellery brands such as PC Totuka & Sons from Jaipur and Pradeep Poddar Jewellers from Kolkata to present their exquisite collections of diamonds, emeralds, rubies and other heirloom creations for the wedding season.” Complementing them are contemporary silver and destination jewellery labels offering statement pieces, showcasing distinctive collections in diamonds, precious stones and fine jewellery that range from bridal heirlooms to contemporary occasion wear.

The showcase also brings together handcrafted saris for the upcoming wedding season, along with summer fashion collections. Among the brands participating in Chennai for the first time are Nishkara from Mumbai, Beyond Stitches from Indore, Eshana from Kolkata and House of Ritika Garima from Delhi. For those looking for festive wear for children, Kolkata-based label Sanctioned by You will be part of the edit.

In addition, the exhibition will feature curated home and lifestyle segments, including luxury bed linen, artisanal décor and festive gifting options. @ Hyatt Regency, Teynampet, August 17 and 18, 11.30am to 7.30pm Entry is free. For details, call 9841246901.

Drop in for VIP hour

If you plan to refresh your festive wardrobe, check out The Haus of Play Edit by Elemental Stories on August 8, where over 35 designers come together under one roof. Browse festive collections by Bhanuni by Jyothi, Nitin Bal Chauhan, Harneet Kaur, Label Vee, Fusion 14, Tulua, Harsh Harsh, Urban Pataka and many more, including several Fashion Week and international labels making their Chennai debut. Shoppers can also enjoy 20% off during the VIP shopping hour from 10am to noon. At The Park, Chennai. On August 8, 10am to 7pm. Curated by Shweta Mahtani and co-hosted by Vimmi Deepak and Sonali Dugar.



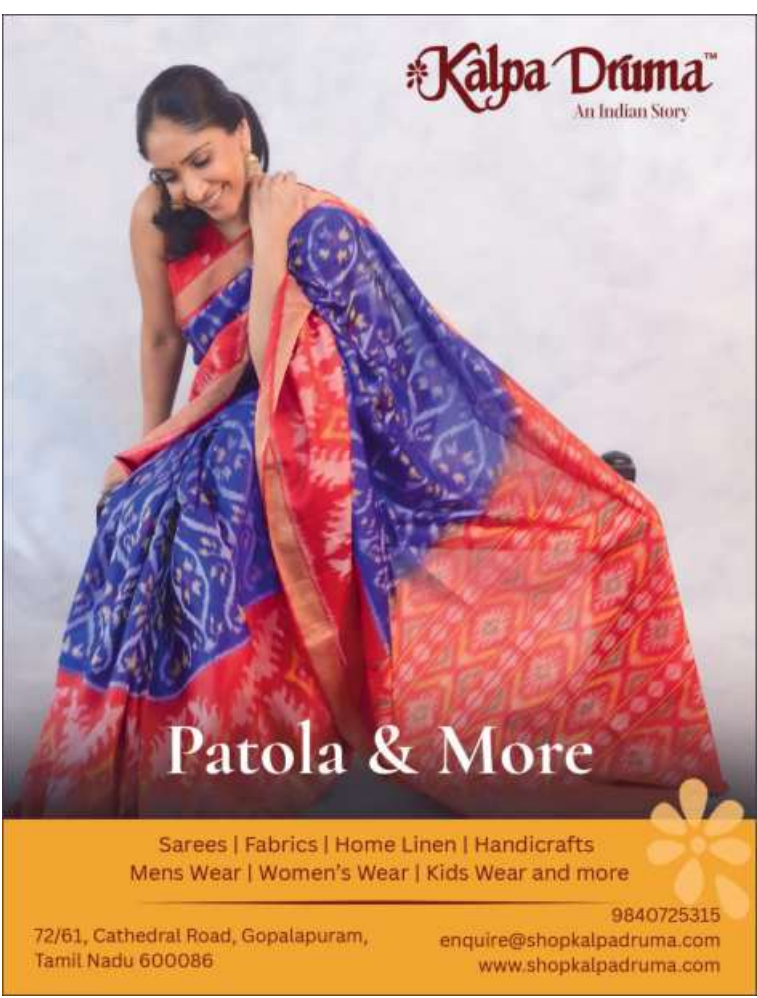
Warp to wardrobe

This weekend, Yali — the textile label by Ally Mathan — is bringing a selection of ready apparel and saris for a two-day pop-up to Collage.

Titled The Aachi’s Wardrobe, the range is an ode to the ‘aachi’, the leader of the Chettinad household. Comprising saris in handspun and handwoven khadi, Venkatgiri, and fine-count Bengal cotton, the range also includes Kanjeevarams, Benares weaves, pashmina saris, and ready apparel such as dresses. The collection features colourways such as madder red, mustard, ledger ink black, kora white, and stone grey, and materials include handwoven cotton, handwoven tussar and mulberry silk, and khadi wool.

Complementing the weaves is an installation that ‘treats the sari as a sculptable medium’. An intricate pallu suspended mid-air lies at the centre of the new range and is ‘aimed at cascading the body of the fabric to highlight its drape and weave density’.

Apparel upwards of ₹5,250, and saris start at ₹10,000. Till August 9, 11am to 7pm. At No 6, Rutland Gate, 4th Street, Nungambakkam.



Carrot 65

From the
Legendary Andhra
Restaurant Chain

ORDER NOW ON

NOW OPEN AT

PORUR

Iyyappanthangal

CUSTOMER CARE

+91 89255 27979

OMR: 8925527979 | VELACHERY: 8925537975 | CHROMEPET: 8925537976
MOUNT ROAD: 9606025158 | THORAIPAKKAM: 8925537978
ANNA NAGAR: 9980600234 | PORUR: 9035522967

Malayalam

A sci-fi comedy with usual alien narratives



S R Praveen
praveen.sr@thehindu.co.in

Just like Vicky (Neeraj Madhav), the protagonist of the sci-fi comedy *Pluto*, who befriends an alien, the movie also does not know what exactly to do with the alien character. This has to do with the nature of the alien. In an attempt to break alien stereotypes, *Pluto* does not have superpowers, except for two skills which are only sparingly used. So, there are only so many exciting things left for the alien to do.

Probably due to tight budgets, the alien also lacks elaborate design elements. Just a spandex suit with a human face (Althaf Salim) does the job. By extension, this would mean that the alien would do familiar Althaf Salim things. One interesting touch that screenwriter Niyas Muhammed and filmmaker Adithyan Chandrasekhar bring to the table is the similarity between Vicky and Pluto, the alien. Both are considered losers in life. Hence, Pluto cannot be of particular use to Vicky, who is down and out after failing with one ill-advised business idea after another.

There was so much potential to create a not-so-common alien narrative and to explore unconventional ideas turning each other's lives around. But other than the attempts at humour, the makers of *Pluto* stick to the usual alien storyline we have seen so many times across languages. Much of it has the mood of the old comic stories in children's magazines. One of the ways the makers attempt to overcome the familiar setting is through light-hearted, comic-book treatment. If one didn't get the hint, there are characters in costumes reminiscent of Shikkari Shambhu and Kuttoosan making their appearance later. The alien's life back home, where alcohol is the major source of energy for the residents, is also used for some situational humour.

The light humour, which works only occasionally, might have carried the film if it had better writing. The friendship between Vicky and Pluto never feels thick enough to evoke the expected emotional pull in the end. The relationship between Vicky and his girlfriend, Meera (Aarsha Chandini Baiju), suffers from less screen time. The gang of thugs led by Tiger Thambi (Aju Varghese), who are out to entrap the alien, just about serve their functional purposes. The lack of a stronger star cast also appears to have worked against the film.

Sci-fi films are not often seen in the Malayalam film industry, which has relatively small budgets, with the subgenre of sci-fi comedies appearing even less frequently. Even the genre's rarity does not help *Pluto*.

Pluto is currently running in cinemas



A largely satisfying crime thriller

Director Rajesh Karna's Telugu film nearly succumbs to the second-half syndrome, but solid drama and clever twists help it sail through

Telugu

Srivathsan Nadadthur

Thrillers have become such an overused genre in recent years, so much so that it feels like an invisible formula is in place to ensure an adrenaline rush. Filmmakers have been relentlessly toying with similar ingredients – violence against women, superstitions, revenge and graphic action designed for shock value – in different proportions, making little effort to craft a satisfying, cinematically-exciting experience.

Writer-director Rajesh Karna brings back the much-needed zing to this space with *Newton's 3rd Law*, a minimalist, noir-like crime thriller. The film frees itself from the excesses associated with a tale featuring familiar faces. The storyteller's intent, for the most part, focuses on staying true to the genre. There is no attempt to oversell the plot or its twists and the execution is sure-footed.

A clear hook for the story is in place as an elderly man named David (Srinivas Avasarala), grows increasingly anxious about a copy of a novel that lands on his doorstep. The novel comprises incidents predominantly set in 1999, where a cop, Vasudev (Sumanth), tries to find a link between two incidents in the city: a college-going youngster dropping dead from a building and a single mother being hit by a speeding car in the middle of the night.

As the officer peels back the layers behind the student's death, multiple theories emerge. Considering the family's dicey financial situation and accounts from those near and dear to the victim – including a suspicious friend, an alcoholic father and a hard-working nurse striving to clear her husband's debts – the tragedy feels less like an accident and more like a

Newton's 3rd Law

Director: Rajesh Karna

Cast: Sumanth, Jagapathi Babu, Srinivas Avasarala

Storyline: A no-nuisance cop investigates a double murder in 1999.

well-orchestrated plot.

One of the major irritants in an investigation thriller is often the forced urgency to heighten the importance of the case and that of the officer's – usually a man's – enhanced flamboyance in resolving it. Vasudev doesn't belong to the breed of super-intelligent cops seen in thrillers. He is cool, calculated and smart, but every second sequence is not written to overstate his investigative acumen.

While Vasudev is the one trying to solve the problem at the heart of the story, the film is more interested in unraveling various angles to the crimes, woven around karma.

The title, *Newton's 3rd Law*, lends the narrative a supposedly scientific dimension, where every action begets an equal and opposite reaction.

Beyond the thrills and deceptive packaging, it also explores the interpersonal drama and tensions that trigger the explosive events. The dead are not merely cases. It speaks of their lost, unlivd existence with sensitivity.

The first half focuses on tropes common to the genre: the incidents, the suspects and the investigation. However, the atmospheric staging allows viewers to look beyond the obvious plot points. The investigation unfolds during the rainy season, the score is relatively upbeat and the dialogue is to the point. The second hour answers all the questions about the crimes, albeit in installments.

Even though the filmmaker attempts to avoid a typical post-interval flashback, the tension dips as the events leading to multiple deaths come to the fore. The precision in the writing is amiss. A few developments are over-explained and the rest are rushed through with an air of restlessness. An edgy twist, the USP of the film, timed for the climax, and the philosophy behind the title are rattled off in a hurry, denting the overall impact.

In an otherwise smart film, Stephen Mercury (Jagapathi Babu) is too stereotypical a villain. Donning his usual

salt-and-pepper look with dapper black suits, smoking a cigar and rolling out the same old dialogues, the menacing killing machine is devoid of a unique personality. David's reactions to the novel towards the end of the film, although justified, are quite over the top.

In Sumanth, though, the film finds a cool, suave protagonist who means business. With a measured, unhurried performance, he makes his presence felt without screaming for attention. Trinadh Varma, playing a vulnerable youngster in a dysfunctional household, proves to be a promising find, striking up a good on-screen rapport with the formidable Pandit Goutham.

Shelley N Kumar and Ravi Varma provide the necessary emotional edge to the film with compelling performances. Neha Pathan is a picture of poise in a crucial role, while others – Abhinayanaa, Rupesh Marrapu and Harini Rao Gaganam – do what is expected of them. However, the other big names, Jagapathi Babu and Srinivas Avasarala, are underwhelming in typical black-and-white characters.

Both the cinematography by Veda Vyas Gottipati, with its innovative lighting, and the music by Sinjith Yerramilli are integral to shaping the film's cool aesthetic. A few commercial liberties are taken in establishing the late 1990s setting with the props, though they do not affect the film significantly. More care could also have been taken to iron out the jerky second hour.

Just when you felt the excitement around investigative thrillers had tapered off, Rajesh Karna's academic, low-stakes approach to the genre makes *Newton's 3rd Law* quite watchable. While a few roadblocks along the way prove distracting, the narrative is a smart fusion of good old tricks and modern-day upgrades.

Newton's 3rd Law is currently running in theatres.

Shahi Kabir's promising meta-narrative loses steam

Malayalam

SR Praveen
praveen.sr@thehindu.co.in

One can sense self-indulgence in the air when a police officer-turned-successful screenwriter writes a film about a policeman struggling to enter the film industry as a scriptwriter, incorporating the uncommon tales that he encountered in service. Shahi Kabir, one of the early players in this peculiar phenomenon of police officers-turned-screenwriters that has swept Malayalam cinema, does not serve a straight-up procedural this time around in *Unmadham*.

Parts of the story unfold in Shelly's (Kunchacko Boban) mind. His long leaves from work and erratic behaviour have made life frustrating for his wife Soumya (Lijomol Jose). Constantly on the lookout for interesting story threads, he lands one when he comes across an old case file with a superstition



attached.

Editor-turned-filmmaker Kiran Das teams up with Kabir in a film that's a shapeshifter in the genre. The mixing of crime with psychological and supernatural

elements works wonders in certain portions. But it also comes across as convenient for the writer in some difficult phases. The central character being a scriptwriter gives the film the extra license to serve up

elements of fantasy amid the actual police procedural, which comes across as a cop out at some points.

One of the weakest links of the film is the old case of a woman's death on which everything hinges.

The background reveal, which can be partly fictional depending on how you look at it, is far from shocking. While some policemen in the film are superstitious, the non-superstitious one tracks down evidence based on mere brainwaves. To make it look plausible, the part gets conveniently portrayed as fiction. Kabir, who is usually on a

sure footing, struggles to maintain balance between different genres in *Unmadham*.

Kunchacko Boban's convincing portrayal of the battles within his mind helps us stay invested in the film, even when the writer seems to be losing grip. Lijomol Jose pulls off her role effectively despite the character being unidimensional. She plays a constantly nagging wife who cools down only when her husband is in imminent danger.

With 'meta' written all over the film, *Unmadham* is not just about the struggles of a police officer who aspires to be in the film industry. It can also be seen as a commentary on the glut of police procedurals based on real-life cases, with the only idea left to be turned into a film being a case file that has superstitious fears attached to it. *Unmadham* goes into the deep recesses of a creative police officer's mind, but manages to come up with only a few interesting crumbs.

Unmadham is currently running in theatres

Cape Fear

Episodes: 10

Creator: Nick Antosca

Starring: Javier Bardem, Amy Adams, Patrick Wilson, Joe Anders, Lily Collias, CCH Pounder, Malia Pyles

Storyline: A dangerous criminal gets out of prison swearing revenge on the lawyers who put him away.



Javier Bardem’s frustrating reboot

English

Mini Anthikad Chhibber
mini.chhibber@thehindu.co.in

From J Lee Thompson’s *Cape Fear* in 1962 and Martin Scorsese’s version of John D MacDonald’s 1957 novel, *The Executioners* in 1991, to the recently concluded series, the story of a man defending his family has been updated to reflect the current worries of the time. Also, considering that the lawyer Sam Bowden in the 1962 film was played by stalwart actor, Gregory Peck, known for his straight back, it effectively ruled out anything sketchy from the man who was to play Atticus Finch only six months later

in *To Kill a Mockingbird*. On the other hand, Robert Mitchum delivered a charmingly sinister performance as the sadistic Max Cady, terrorising Bowden and his family for putting him in prison. By the time one comes to Nick Antosca’s version of *Cape Fear* with Scorsese and Steven Spielberg as executive producers, one could hardly be blamed for expecting, if not a nuanced reading of the anxieties of the age, then at least a rip-roaring psychological thriller. Considering the star cast, with Javier Bardem as Cady, Amy Adams and Patrick Wilson playing the lawyers Anna and Tom Bowden who put Cady away, *Cape Fear* could at least have been solid, pulpy fun. Alas, giant plot holes appear with

alarming regularity, characters behave in the oddest ways, stakes are non-existent as every threat dissipates even as Bernard Herrmann’s jangly discordant strings try to strike terror. Anna was Max’s lawyer when he was convicted of killing his pregnant wife and Tom was the prosecuting counsel. Anna convinced Max to take a plea deal and go to prison. Now, 17 years later, Anna and Tom are married with two children, Zack (Joe Anders) and Natalie (Lily Collias). Max is released from prison when new evidence turns up and is determined to avenge himself on Anna and Tom whom he sees as profiting from his incarceration. For successful lawyers, Anna and Tom make remarkably un-lawyerly decisions including hiding crucial bits of evidence while Natalie and Zack seem to live and operate in a world of terrible choices. The police, Anna’s boss, podcasters, practically

everyone in the *Cape Fear* world make inexplicable decisions. The police choose not to leave even one officer at Bowden’s home, after Max has escaped (again). Jail seems to have a revolving door policy with everyone going in and out. In the finale, Bardem has some fun going for broke, which also does not quite take off as the rest of cast give him the side-eye to all his dreadful proclamations. The violence is quite excessive with people biting off toes and smashing heads in, but it does not contribute to the story or characters. By the end of its 10 episodes, there’s little to be thankful for beyond the family pet (a cat this time, not the dog from the films) making it through unharmed, the striking, saturated cinematography, and Blue Öyster Cult’s iconic song ‘(Don’t Fear) The Reaper’.

Cape Fear is currently streaming on Apple TV+

Snippets



Tiger, Remo team up

Producer and entrepreneur Vicky Jain has launched his new production banner VJ Frames. The banner’s first film will be headlined by Tiger Shroff, helmed by Remo D’Souza, and will also feature Abhishek Banerjee and Elvish Yadav in pivotal roles. The currently untitled film will mark the first part in an ambitious, high-octane action franchise, said the makers. Further, the banner is set to develop a diverse slate of films across genres. Remo and Tiger have previously collaborated on the 2016 superhero actioner, *A Flying Jatt*, which also starred Jacqueline Fernandez in the lead. Tiger was last seen in *Baaghi 4* in 2025. Meanwhile, Remo’s last directorial was the Abhishek Bachchan starrer *Be Happy*.



Warner Bros. Discovery unveils new Animal Planet documentary

Warner Bros. Discovery announced the launch of *India: Epic Wild Stories*, a documentary anthology on Animal Planet that celebrates the country’s biodiversity through the lens of acclaimed Indian filmmakers. The series will feature monthly premieres, spanning across the country’s diverse ecosystems and will offer a deeper look into India’s natural world and the people working to protect it. The first documentary in the series, a six-part series called *Shared Spaces*, has been released on Animal Planet. The docu-series is hosted by award-winning environmental journalist Bahar Dutt and filmed by National Award-winning cinematographer Vijay Bedi.



Manikandan to headline Neelam Studios’ Makkal Kaavalan

Tamil actor K Manikandan is all set to headline the upcoming action drama, *Makkal Kaavalan*, the makers announced on August 5 with a first look. Written and directed by Santhosh Kumar, the film is set to be produced by Birla Studios and Neelam Studios. “*Makkal Kaavalan* follows a simple man determined to live with dignity until a corrupt system leaves him with only two choices: surrender or resist. What begins as one man’s struggle for survival grows into something far larger, forcing him to become a leader he never sought to be,” reads the press release. With music scored by Nivas K Prasanna, the film has cinematography by Pratheepan Selvaratnam.



Tom Holland finally swings free

Destin Daniel Cretton rescues Spider-Man from the MCU’s multiversal slop and returns him to the friendly neighbourhood that made him extraordinary

English

Ayaan Paul Chowdhury
ayaan.paul@thehindu.co.in

Ever since Thanos snapped half the universe out of existence and *Endgame* painstakingly stitched the Marvel Cinematic Universe back together, Marvel has been trapped inside its own museum, endlessly dusting off relics from a past it cannot stop monetising. With *Spider-Man: Brand New Day*, helmed by director Destin Daniel Cretton, the studio finally seems to have come to terms with the exhaustion from multiversal slop. Cretton inherits perhaps the bleakest ending any live-action Peter Parker has received. At the conclusion of *Spider-Man: No Way Home*, Tom Holland’s Peter willingly erased himself from everybody’s memory to prevent the collapse of reality itself, sacrificing his relationships with MJ (Zendaya) and best friend Ned Leeds (Jacob Batalon) so the wider world could survive. Writers Chris McKenna and Erik Sommers ground Peter’s grief inside recognisable routines. Years after Aunt May’s death, *Brand New Day* finds him living alone in a cramped apartment, obsessively following Ned’s social media updates from afar while New York celebrates Spider-Man without knowing the exhausted young man underneath the mask. That carefully engineered solitude begins to fracture when a string of unsettling possession cases sweeps across New York, leaving seemingly ordinary civilians violently commandeered by an unseen telepathic force whose trail repeatedly converges on Damage Control, the government agency established after the Battle of New York to recover and regulate alien technology. Peter initially approaches the attacks as another neighbourhood emergency before discovering that whatever is moving from body to body is hunting something hidden inside Damage Control’s HQ. The central conflict cleverly externalises Peter’s psychological deterioration through biology. His mutated arachnid

Spider-Man: Brand New Day

Director: Destin Daniel Cretton

Cast: Tom Holland, Destin Daniel Cretton, Jacob Batalon, Sadie Sink, Jon Bernthal, Mark Ruffalo, Ayo Edebiri, Colman Domingo, Tramell Tillman, Tony Revolori, Marisa Tomei

Storyline: A forgotten Peter Parker lives alone as a full-time Spider-Man until mounting pressure triggers a dangerous change and a powerful new enemy emerges.

DNA begins changing again, producing debilitating headaches and triggering organic web production that he struggles to control. The changing physiology accompanies Peter’s inability to reconcile permanent loss with continuing responsibility. Simultaneously, the unseen telepath capable of transferring consciousness between unwilling hosts infiltrates New York while targeting Damage Control. Holland delivers his richest performance since joining the MCU because the writing finally retires Peter from his long-running side hustle as Kevin Feige’s most reliable diplomatic envoy between competing corners of the Marvel Universe, and restores him to the centre of his own story. There remains something fundamentally, almost suspiciously, nice about Holland, that no amount of blockbuster machinery has managed to sand away, and that innate decency continues to make him an uncannily convincing Peter Parker. Contemporary superhero cinema has developed an almost pathological fear of letting its protagonists carry a film by themselves. Every new release seems contractually obligated to wheel in a parade of recognisable faces, as though audiences might wander off unless another piece of intellectual property walks into frame every half hour. *Brand New Day* inevitably plays the crossover game too, yet none of the appearances feel contrived. Frank Castle, Bruce Banner and the film’s other familiar faces each deepen Peter’s emotional journey or reinforce the story’s central ideas. The returning cast benefits from that as well. Zendaya retains considerable command despite comparatively limited screen time, finding subtle behavioural shifts that plausibly suggest forgotten intimacy. Jacob Batalon enjoys the film’s biggest reset, shedding the perpetual sidekick energy that defined Ned across earlier entries in favour of someone noticeably cooler, more confident and unexpectedly charismatic. Meanwhile, newcomer Sadie Sink’s “secret” role has been one of Hollywood’s worst-kept secrets for months. She has always been the standout performer to emerge from *Stranger Things*, and she carries those

instincts into the MCU without missing a beat. The biggest surprise, however, belongs behind the camera. Spider-Man has always belonged to New York in a way few iconic superheroes genuinely belong anywhere and Cretton’s Spidey-sense understood this instinctively. Brett Pawlak’s cinematography spends time observing grimy bodegas, fire-escapes, corner stores, elevated train tracks, and the stunning amber glow washing across Midtown just before dusk. Cretton shamelessly raids *Insomniac’s Marvel’s Spider-Man* games for their sense of velocity, embracing long, uninterrupted first-person swings, stomach-dropping dives and momentum that actually respects gravity. And so for the first time in years, traversing Manhattan feels like something Peter does because he loves it, not because the plot needs him three boroughs away before the next quip. Cretton approaches Spider-Man with far greater personality. Everything carries a little more swagger, confidence, and perhaps most importantly, a sense that somebody behind the camera actually wanted to make a *Spider-Man* film instead of simply another Marvel film featuring Spider-Man. I have also long maintained that the MCU has been the least interesting place Spider-Man has ever lived. Every incarnation that has ever existed beyond its borders, understood that Peter Parker only works when his world feels intensely personal. But the MCU reduced him to a likable employee, forever attending crossover obligations and waiting for the next Avengers meeting to begin. *Brand New Day* finally severs that umbilical cord. This is the first MCU *Spider-Man* film that anchors the same scrappy, neighbourhood soul that once had me launching myself off sofas as a kid, convinced my web-shooters simply hadn’t activated yet. Peter once again feels inseparable from the stubborn optimism and relentless exhaustion of ordinary people trying to survive another impossible day in NYC (call that Spider-Mamdani if you will), and that has always been his greatest superpower.

Spider-Man: Brand New Day is currently running in theatres